PRIVACY & SAFETY

AI Privacy Checklist

Share less. Check more. Breathe easier.

A short, repeatable privacy routine for the AI tools you actually use — including the part most checklists skip: what to do after a mistake.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 The pause before you paste
02 The ten-minute account checkup
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04 Work and healthcare boundaries
05 A plan for “I shared too much”

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Before you paste

Most AI privacy problems do not start with a hacker. They start with a helpful person pasting something private into a box that felt like a conversation. Use this page as a pause button.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **The billboard test**
>
> If it would bother you to see this on a billboard with your name attached, do not paste it into a general consumer AI tool without a real reason, an approved tool, and a plan to redact.

Sort the information first

Usually fine

Public policies, product manuals, your own non-sensitive brainstorming, generic recipes, and anonymized category totals.

Still check copyright and platform terms before republishing what an AI generates.

Slow down

Your contact details, calendar specifics, drafts about identifiable people, unfinished work, personal photos, and location details.

Ask: do I need this exact detail for the task? Use a placeholder if not.

Stop and rethink

Government IDs, financial account numbers, passwords or API keys, patient and client records, private images of other people, and confidential legal or HR documents.

Use an approved tool, a qualified human, or a safer process.

Red is not a permanent “never.” It means this data carries real consequences: do not put it into a general-purpose tool without authorization, minimization, and a clear need.

The four-question pause

- ☐ **Need:** Is this exact detail necessary for the task?
- ☐ **Eyes:** Would I be okay if a coworker, client, or family member saw it?
- ☐ **Others:** Does this include someone else’s private information or story?
- ☐ **Permission:** Am I allowed to use this tool for this kind of data?

If any answer is no, redact it, replace it with a placeholder, or stop. A slightly less specific prompt is almost always better than a privacy cleanup later.

INSTEAD OF	TRY
A real name, phone, or email	[client], [family member], [email]
An account or card number	[account], [last four only]
A full address or workplace	[small town], [large employer]
A confidential project name	[new product], [internal project]

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The ten-minute account checkup

Menu labels move around. Look for the behavior, not the exact words. Useful sections are often called Privacy, Data controls, Data & privacy, Personalization, Memory, Connected apps, or Security.

Data and history

- ☐ **Find the training control.** If the service lets you opt out of using chats to improve models, choose that. It usually affects future content, not what is already stored.
- ☐ **Review your history.** Delete conversations and uploaded files that contain sensitive information. Emptying a chat may not erase backup copies immediately.
- ☐ **Use temporary chats when offered.** They are useful for one-off questions you do not want saved in your main history.
- ☐ **Clear memory and personalization.** Remove stored details you do not want the tool to reuse — names, preferences, projects, or health details.
- ☐ **Check shared conversations.** Turn off link sharing and revoke old links that may still work.
- ☐ **Download your data if you need a record.** Keep it somewhere private, and remember that a full export is itself sensitive.

Access and account security

- ☐ **Remove unfamiliar connected apps, plugins, or connectors.** Look for anything with access to email, files, calendars, or accounts.
- ☐ **Check mobile permissions.** Does the app really need your contacts, microphone, photos, or files? Limit anything that is not needed.
- ☐ **Review browser extensions.** Remove AI add-ons and extensions you do not use, especially ones that can read and change every page.
- ☐ **Use a unique password and multi-factor authentication.** Prefer a passkey or authenticator app over text-message codes when possible.
- ☐ **Separate work and personal accounts.** This limits what gets mixed together when you switch contexts.
- ☐ **Repeat the pass quarterly.** Settings change, features appear, and old permissions linger. A recurring calendar reminder is the whole trick.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Delete is not always gone**
>
> A chat can be removed from your screen while copies remain in backups, logs, or a service's records for a period defined in its policy. Delete what you can, opt out where offered, and prevent the next paste instead of promising yourself the perfect cleanup.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Connected tools need a second look

A connector can read your files, send email, post to a calendar, or act in an app for you. That convenience is also an expansion of what can go wrong. Permission is not consent forever.

Before you connect anything

- ☐ **What can it read?** Name the actual data: one file, all email, a calendar, a customer database.
- ☐ **What can it write or do?** Reading is not the same as sending, deleting, purchasing, or posting publicly.
- ☐ **Whose data is included?** Your files may contain other people's messages, health details, or work secrets.
- ☐ **Where does the data go?** Is it processed in the cloud, kept for how long, and used to improve a model?
- ☐ **How do I revoke it?** Find the off switch before you connect, and know whether removing the app also deletes past data.
- ☐ **Is there a lower-access option?** Paste one redacted excerpt instead of connecting the whole drive.

Start lower on the ladder

RUNG	WHAT IT MEANS	SAFER DEFAULT
One	You type a question in a chat	Keep sensitive details out
Two	The AI reads one document you choose	Remove names and account numbers
Three	The AI can search email, files, or calendar	Use a work-approved tool; limit scope
Four	The AI can write, send, post, or delete	Require review before action
Five	The AI can spend money or change access	Keep a human approval step every time

TRY THIS

Matches on the web are not instructions

A web page or document can contain hidden directions aimed at an AI assistant. If a tool can browse or read files, treat outside content as untrusted — especially when the tool can also take actions.

Local-first is a direction, not a halo

Running a model on your own computer can reduce what leaves your device. It does not automatically make a workflow private. The browser extension, synced notes app, backup service, or screen recorder around it may still collect data. Ask the same four questions: what goes in, what is stored, who can see it, and how do I remove it?

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

At work and in healthcare

Work information belongs to more than one person. A policy exists because a mistake can affect a patient, customer, employee, or the organization you work for. “Everyone uses AI” is not the same as “you are allowed to use this tool for this data.”

Before using AI for work

- ☐ **Check the approved-tools list.** If you cannot find one, ask your manager, IT, privacy, or compliance team before pasting.
- ☐ **Use the work account when provided.** Personal accounts are usually outside your employer’s reviewed environment.
- ☐ **Minimize the data.** Remove names, record numbers, dates of birth, addresses, contact details, and anything not needed for the task.
- ☐ **Do not paste contracts, HR matters, incident reports, or legal advice** into an unapproved tool.
- ☐ **Keep a human reviewer** for anything consequential, public, or sent to another person.
- ☐ **Label the draft.** “AI-assisted draft, reviewed by [name]” is clearer than pretending every first draft was fully human.

For healthcare workers

- ☐ **Never enter protected health information (PHI)** — names, medical record numbers, birth dates, diagnoses, test results, images, schedules that reveal care — into a general-purpose AI tool unless your employer has explicitly approved that use.
- ☐ **Treat patient stories as private.** Changing a name is not automatically de-identification. A rare condition, small town, date, age, or job can identify someone.
- ☐ **Use non-identifiable educational questions.** Ask about a condition in general; do not paste a patient message, chart note, or image.
- ☐ **Verify clinical information** with current approved clinical resources and qualified colleagues. An AI is not a clinical authority.
- ☐ **Escalate pressure to use an unapproved tool.** Ask in writing and follow your organization’s reporting policy.

WATCH OUT

This is education, not compliance advice

HIPAA, state law, licensing rules, and your employer’s policies may all apply — and they can be stricter than this page. When in doubt, stop before the paste and ask the person whose job is privacy at your organization.

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If you overshared

Shame is not a recovery plan. Act quickly, stay specific, and fix what is fixable. Most of this is about limiting the damage and getting the right person involved early.

The practical sequence

01 **Name exactly what left your hands.** Was it text, a file, a screenshot, a voice note, or a link? Which account and tool? When? Write it down before memory gets fuzzy.

02 **Remove it from the current view.** Delete the message or file if the tool allows. Check trash and shared links too. You may also need to remove the content from a synced folder.

03 **Revoke access.** Disconnect the app, turn off the public link, and sign out of shared devices. Enable multi-factor authentication.

04 **Rotate exposed credentials from another trusted device.** Passwords need changing. API keys, access tokens, and recovery codes need revoking. Never paste a real secret into an AI chat to ask whether it is sensitive.

05 **Use the provider's privacy controls.** Opt out of training where offered, check the retention policy, and submit a deletion request through official support if needed. Do not assume instant removal.

06 **Tell the right human early.** For work, client, patient, or customer data, follow the incident policy and tell your manager or privacy officer. For financial data, contact the bank or card issuer. If identity theft is a risk, use official reporting channels.

07 **Keep a short record.** Date, data, tool, actions taken, people informed, and anything still open. A timeline is more useful than a spiral.

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My containment record

What was shared:

Where it went and when:

People informed / next check:

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **A mistake is not a character flaw**
>
> It is a data-handling event. Do not pour more sensitive details into a chat while asking how to fix the first leak — and do not quietly delete evidence your workplace is required to preserve. Get help.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Your household privacy plan

Privacy is shared when the laptop is. A family plan does not need to be complicated; it needs a few agreed habits and a device that locks.

House rules worth agreeing on

- ☐ **Use separate profiles or accounts** on shared computers and tablets. One unlocked adult account is a group project nobody wants.
- ☐ **Ask before uploading someone else's data.** Photos, voices, messages, and health details belong to the person they describe.
- ☐ **Keep private chats off shared screens.** Use temporary chats for one-offs and log out of public or shared devices.
- ☐ **Talk about synthetic media.** Anyone can make a convincing fake image or voice. Verify urgent requests through a second channel.
- ☐ **Protect young users.** Use age-appropriate accounts and supervision; discuss what should never be shared, including school, location, and images of friends.
- ☐ **Help older relatives pause on "urgent" messages.** A callback to a known number is stronger than a frantic chat reply.

Our data map

WHERE WE USE AI	WHAT PRIVATE DETAIL MIGHT APPEAR	SAFER HABIT

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Our three house rules

Rule 1

Rule 2

Rule 3

The quarterly reset

- ☐ Delete old chats with personal information.
- ☐ Check training and memory settings.
- ☐ Remove unused apps, extensions, and connectors.
- ☐ Rotate shared passwords and check MFA.
- ☐ Revisit this plan together.

> TRY THIS
>
> **Make the easy choice the safe choice**
>
> Keep the private laptop profile locked, put the approved work tool on the work profile, and keep a small “no personal details” note near the shared computer. Privacy gets better when it requires fewer decisions.

ONE LAST THING · 03

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Do the ten-minute account checkup, then put a quarterly privacy reset on your calendar. One small appointment is worth a dozen good intentions.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

01 AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

02 Beginner AI Glossary

04 AI for Job Search

05 AI for Budgeting

06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.